

match a shipper with a trucker, and facilitate payments, insurance and other financial services. “Even before we pitched our idea, Accel had a very clear thesis on the kind of company they wanted to invest in in the trucking space, so we are really grateful that they picked us. Ever since, they’ve played a significant role in our journey, staying invested, and backing us across rounds,” says Rajesh Yabaji, Co-founder and CEO of BlackBuck. Accel had led a \$5-million seed investment in the company in 2015, and made two more investments in subsequent rounds. Yabaji is an IIT Kharagpur graduate who was heading the supply chain division of ITC’s leaf tobacco business before striking out on his own in 2015 to start BlackBuck.

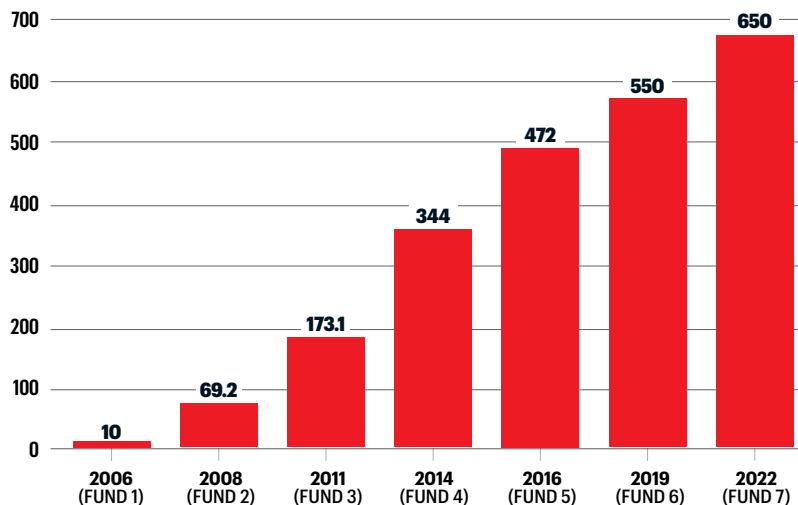
But securing funding is just the beginning for start-ups. Having a supportive investor that understands the ins and outs of a fledgling venture is integral to its growth and sustainability. Yabaji says that Accel helped the company from day one across areas including hiring, product development, and operations, and its Partner—Anand Daniel, who led the investment for Accel—has been more like a co-founder for the company, than an investor.

“We share our ups and downs with Daniel, celebrate all our milestones, and really built BlackBuck together in the last seven years. We had to hire over a thousand people within our first six months, and we had to completely lean on Accel’s portfolio services team. They helped us set up several governance frameworks, functions, and processes in the organisation so that we could transition across stages of growth in a smooth manner,” Yabaji says.

From an investor’s perspective though, the ball just starts rolling with the first investment into an up and coming start-up. For them, getting the start-up’s product market fit and helping it raise follow-on

ACCEL’S INDIA FUNDS

The market value of Accel’s India portfolio is worth over \$100 billion today



FUND SIZE IN \$ MILLION; SOURCE: ACCEL

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rounds is just the beginning of a long journey, and an investor-partner has to don many hats on a daily basis, explains Barath Shankar Subramanian, a Partner with Accel who focusses on Cloud/SaaS, consumer and healthcare companies.

“The bulk of our portfolio is early-stage where lots of things need to be proven. With companies that are at scale, the relationship switches to where you get involved with more high-level things, and not the nitty-gritty. You [investors] are essentially their sounding board, there to come up with pointed solutions that might help. That is the most value add you can do. Founders know what’s best,” says Subramanian.

By focussing on growing its portfolio companies, the fund has also grown internally. From a 6-7 member team managing \$69 million in capital in 2008-09, the company now has a team of 60 people operat-

ing a \$650-million early-stage fund dedicated to India and the Southeast Asian markets. The market value of Accel’s India portfolio is worth over \$100 billion today, and its total commitment to the region has crossed the \$2-billion mark with the latest fund. Except for Sequoia India, no other India-focussed fund has committed as much investments in the country as Accel has.

“We have grown almost 10x in terms of the fund size, and our overall capital under management has probably grown about 30x. So, internally we have had to scale. Our investment team is fairly set for the amount of capital that we are managing. We have a large analyst team with a very structured analyst programme. We have finance and legal teams that support us. Vertical functions like marketing and corporate development support us not just internally, but also our portfolio